

Broken Archive Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	broken-archive

Big idea: The past survives as incomplete traces.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Broken Archive Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Broken Archive Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Broken Archive Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Broken Archive Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A source silence note asking who is absent and why. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The past survives as incomplete traces.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Broken Archive Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Broken Archive Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices.
- Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards.
- A source silence note asking who is absent and why.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Give each group a different combination of sources.
2. Groups reconstruct what happened.
3. Groups compare narratives and identify what evidence they lacked.
4. The class ranks which sources were most useful and most dangerous.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?
- How do historians deal with missing evidence?
- Is history discovered, constructed or both?

Knowledge Questions

- Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?
- How do historians deal with missing evidence?
- Is history discovered, constructed or both?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...